



SOAK IN THE MOMENT

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At Spa-Francorchamps, unpredictability is tradition. The inevitable rain around the Ardennes region in Belgium always adds a layer of risk and chaos to the 7km-long circuit — the longest track on the calendar — which rewards the brave and punishes hesitation.

The clouds had been looming for hours, and when the showers began, the start of the Belgian Grand Prix was pushed back for more than an hour. But in a weekend of shifting fortunes and grabbing at strands of opportunity, it was Oscar Piastri (**above**) who prevailed.

The 24-year-old made the boldest impression, outmanoeuvring and outlasting his teammate Lando Norris in a race of fine margins that now define McLaren's season, and the championship battle.

Making a move

The advantage swung back and forth between the McLaren drivers almost from one session to the next. The papaya pair split the poles — Piastri dominated the sprint qualifying, while Norris struck in the main race, edging his teammate by barely a tenth.

But pole position is often seen as a double-edged sword at Spa-Francorchamps, and they were both at the receiving end. It was last in 2021 that the front-runner was able to maintain his advantage, albeit in an uncharacteristic fashion — Max Verstappen won the

two-lap affair, which awarded half points to drivers.

First in line for the harsh reward was Piastri, who lined up ahead of the Dutchman (a three-time Belgian GP winner in the Sprint). The looming threat for the Australian was not his teammate starting from third, but the Red Bull sandwiched in between.

One can always expect Verstappen to pull off a stunning overtake on the opening lap, and the events unfolded soon enough. Flat out through Eau Rouge and into the Kemmel Straight — the first few turns of the track — the reigning champion used the tow to soar past Piastri in remarkable, gutsy, Verstappen-like fashion.

From there, he remained in total control of the 15-lap affair to win his first sprint of the season. It was his 12th career sprint victory — more than all other sprint winners combined (9). Piastri finished second, Norris third, but the psychological edge had begun to shift.